

Aristotle has a unique conception of nature. He outlines the order of nature first through the lens of biology, constructing a hierarchy in which plants exist for the sake of animals, and animals for the sake of humans (Aristotle, *Politics*, 1.8.1256b15-18). He establishes this as a foundational biological framework through which the purpose of all living things is determined by their nature from birth through full development. As such, there is a biological basis for their purpose, as these stages are gated by the organism's biological clock of age. He then extends this hierarchy to human beings, stating that "anyone who, despite being human, is by nature not his own but someone else's is a natural slave." (Aristotle, *Politics*, 1.4.1254a13-17) The slave, on this view, occupies a place in the natural order just as animals do, born into a role determined by nature itself, and based on his prior reasoning for property, the slave must then be for the master, born so, and raised so.

But this raises a critical question: is the biological aspect of nature Aristotle's primary argument for slavery? Two central lines of reasoning emerge from his arguments in the text, and they contradict one another in a revealing way. In Chapter 2, Aristotle argues that a natural ruler is one capable of rational foresight, while one who can only labor with their body is naturally ruled (Aristotle, *Politics*, 1.2.1252a30-34). This grounds the distinction in rational capacity, a feature of the individual that is independent of their ethnic origin. If this argument is grounded in rational capacity, then it is the placement of natural slaves under the master by virtue of their biology. However, Aristotle also invokes the poets, stating "it is proper for Greeks to rule non-Greeks," implying that non-Greek and slave are the same by nature (Aristotle, *Politics*, 1.2.1252b5-9). Here the hierarchy is ethnic and birth-based, where one is a natural slave because of where and to whom they were born. These two criteria pull in opposite directions. If natural slavery is determined by rational capacity, then a non-Greek capable of rational foresight would

not qualify as a natural slave, yet the poets' argument would still subordinate them. If ethnic origin is the true criterion, then Aristotle's biological framework does no real work, as the hierarchy would be fixed by cultural birth rather than nature. It is unclear which criterion Aristotle takes to be primary, and whether his biological conception of nature can coherently support his defense of slavery at all, as they would demand evidence of the natural slave's lack of rational capacity. It is necessary to understand, furthermore, which argument takes precedence in situations where they contradict, such as in this question of how Aristotle would argue against the equality of all humans.